



NO MORE HEROES

THE SLOW DEMISE OF THE SUPERHERO GAMES

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As a kid, I'd feverishly wait for Saturday morning because that was the time that the X-Men animated series would air on Star World. Yes, I'm that old! To say that I've loved comics and superheroes would be an understatement. I've been collecting comics since I was 5 and I'm almost 40 now. So, you do the math. I'd wait for movies like *Spawn* and *Steel* just to catch a live-action glimpse of the heroes I'd worshipped on pulp pages. It was the same story when it came to games. I vividly remember the 8-bit *Captain America* and the *Avengers* where you'd battle supervillains like The Wizard, Crossbones, and Ultron on the Nintendo Entertainment System. There was a slate of DC games on the Super Nintendo

as well, with the *Death and Return of Superman* being my personal favourite. The Sega Master System also saw games like *Comix Zone* and more. But as we've been getting more watered-down, corporatized versions of our favourite characters, the same level of malaise seems to be seeping into the gaming world as well. Without any sort of gatekeeping, the comic book world has been dealing with an infection of people who have no attachment to the product apart from driving it into the dirt. This has moved into the gaming world as well with the dismal announcement of *Suicide Squad: Kill the Justice League*. Like, stop trying to make Harley Quinn happen, guys! Please Stop! (We'll dive a little deeper into why the latest game by Rocksteady was so cringe-worthy.)

Sure, there will always be the odd *Spider-Man 2018* and the *Batman Arkham* series here and there but with the Disneyfication of Marvel and DC playing catch up, the superhero game has been kicked to the curb. I tried playing Square Enix's *Avengers* game and I felt physically ill. The game was full of the worst predatory gaming practices with loot boxes and *Games as a Live Service* jammed into a terrible story with even more cringe-worthy graphics. They may have some of the biggest box office hits but Marvel does not have the same luck when it comes to gaming. Again, apart from the *Spider-Man* games (which had little to no input from Marvel, since the rights to *Spider-Man* belong to Sony), literally, every Marvel video game is the bottom-of-the-barrel, discount bin stuff. All the great Marvel games have